Woman's best friend

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37108231.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F

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by the_Frank

Summary

Catherine "Wildcat" DaCosta doesn’t live the best life, but it's okay. She could have more money, but hey, she manages perfectly on her own! And some people bug her for being single, but really, what do they know? She has good friends, she gets to be bossy and rude at work, and she has her faithful (and waaay to energetic) dog Adora to keep her company. Love and relationships isn't her bag, and besides, her apartment (and bed) is to small.

And then, one day, during playtime in the park, Adora finds a dogfriend.

To bad that dogs owner is the biggest jerk ever. With big brown eyes and stupid, sparkling hair.

Happy Valentines day 2022.

Notes

We all know Adora is a Golden Retriever. This is just the natural development of things.

Rewrite of an old story of mine. A gift for my dear friends Bagge and Randomized Mongoose.

13th of August.

The apartment was small. It boasted two rooms: one a bedroom, the other a combined kitchen/dining room. Some visitors would argue that this was an inconvenience and some more impertinent people would say that it was a sign of the economic standard of the person inhabiting it. Catherine would ask both categories to eff off, grumpily adding (if she was in a good mood) that it was only an inconvenience if you had more than three people over at once or used more utensils than the microwave on a daily basis. And she wasn't *poor* , she just had better things to spend money on than a bigger apartment. The last category was also prone to never be spoken to ever again.

A small throng, which the landlord without shame called a hallway, led to the front door. It also contained the apartment's only door, behind which was the toilet and a bath with shower. This was the one part of the apartment that held a higher standard. Catherine had once dated a plumber who offered to renovate it for her. The relationship ended and she was sent an invoice later with a note attached saying "take me back or pay." That was the happiest 800$ she'd ever spent, even if she had to live on noodles for five months. It was worth at least double, and she miiiight have been standing in front of her mirror pretending to be a kardashian once or twice. Not that she would ever admit it, and she doubted that Kim K ever spent time in a bathroom anyway. She probaly had slaves for that business.

A drapery made from mock-bamboo separated the bedroom from the kitchening room. The main color of the apartment was yellow, but the drapery was painted a shock pink, for the single reason that it made people look funny when they saw it.

The kitchening room had three main pieces of furniture. A wall-mounted flat screen Tv (One months pay but when one wants to binge watch HBO shows, you get the equipment suitable for it.), a kitchen island (mainly used to staple cartons of leftovers on, and said microwave) and a brown sofa, way too large for a single

person household to sit on. It was however perfect to doze off on, or play a relaxing game of Fortnite in, therefore it was not placed with the broad end but the short end towards the TV. the tap in the kitchen was slowly releasing waterdrops in the sink. The leak wasn’t that annoying, but the apartments owner had decided that enough was enough. The plumber was coming next week. As always, they charged a bit to much, but she had had enough. The dripping sound was at worst a 3 a.m. and tonight it had woken her up briefly.

The bedroom was furnished with one large single bed. Framework, thick mattress, thin mattress, sheet, duvet and pillow. The bedroom's walls were pretty bare, save for two things. A poster of a train that had run through a wall and the quote "Oh shit" written on it. There was also a digital clock clutched to the wall that was designed to look like a computer screen, and except the time, you could tell the date, outside and inside temperature and air pressure. It was old and rather tacky, but it did its job. At the moment it showed time being 7.57 am to absolutely no one since the woman who inhabited the apartment was very much asleep.

One item in the apartment didn’t have a fixed position, or well… It was supposed to have, but was constantly whisked around. It was a blue plastic bowl that for a short time each day contained dog food. Suddenly there was a rustle in the bamboo as said bowl shot through the bars, accompanied by eager paws against the linoleum mat. The bowl was gently placed on the floor, where the person on the bed could see it, then the paws were on the bed, and then a face had a close encounter with a dog's tongue.

Catherine reluctantly opened her eyes. One gold and one turquoise eye looked right into the two light blue, very happy and very excited eyes of a Golden Retriever. *Her* golden retriever, unfortunately.

"Adora, for crying out loud…"

"Woff!"

Catherine rolled over and closed her eyes. Adora tilted her head slightly, as if in wonder how mommy could miss the empty food bowl. Then she jumped back up on the bed and gave her mistress another lick on her face. Without opening her eyes Catherine muttered: "Adora… It's Sunday… Let mommy sleep, please…"

"Woof!"

"Surprise, you're hungry." She yawned and shut her eyes. "I don't care. It's too early. Get out. Go… back to the sofa and come back after the cartoons, ok?"

Adora blinked, and jumped off the bed. Catherine sighed satisfied and began to doze off…

...when suddenly she felt how the thin mattress was being pulled off the bed and down on the floor.

"Adora! No! Stop! Bad girl! Baaaaa…"

Thomp

"Woof!"

Catherine sat up, wiped off her face with the quilt and gave her pet a look that would have killed weaker people. Adora just looked back at her with her usual happy face, and gave out a proud bark.

"Woof!"

"Adora, you bitch! BITCH I tell you! Bitch… Why am I even trying? You don't even get offended by that..."

"Woof!"

"I could have gotten a gold fish or an ant farm but apparently that 'doesn't count' as a support animal…"

Satisfied with mommy finally out of bed, Adora grabbed her bown, turned, and wagging her tail she left the room for the kitchen.

Catherine slowly got up from the floor, yawned and scratched herself wherever it was necessary. At that moment, her phone rang.

Caller: Scorpia.

"It's too early…" She still answered the call. "What do you want?"

"Morning to you too, Wildcat! I'm not going to ask if I woke you up, I know Adora took care of that."

"It's too early for nicknames, scorp…"

"Sorry, sorry! Catherine. Though it's a teeeensy bit unfair that you get to call me a nick when I…"

"I am licensed to kill anyone who talks to me before breakfast.."

"I don't think that would hold to court, cat."

"Try me." She knew that wouldn't stop Scorpia and back in her head she was grateful that she never seemed to take anything Catherine said to heart. Probably. Hopefully. Some part of her knew she took her friend for granted, but with that kind of response…

"You're always so grumpy, wildcat! You should start the day with some simple workouts or maybe a yoga routine! Patricia showed me some, it's the best way to fill yourself with energy to…"

"Scorpia. I am hanging up on you in 3. 2. 1…"

"Okay, okay! Geez, you really ought to switch to decaf. I called to remind you about the traditional Sunday Brunch! Patricia spent almost the whole evening yesterday preparing and the whole house smells delicious! You would think even the toilet chair was a soup tureen!"

There was a short silence.

"But seriously. Don't. It's not. No really. It's not."

"Scorpia, I haven't forgotten. You reminded me Thursday *and* Friday lunch. And yesterday at the AW. I don't buy that you're calling me for that."

"What? nooo, I just wanted to…"

"Scorpia…"

"Well, um… What was that honey?"

Some high pitched mumbling in the background, and the Scorpia's voice returned. *"Okay, yes. Face your fears head on, the worst thing that can happen is only in your mind. SO, WILDC…atherine. If you* happen *to pass work on your way to us, can you bring me another form for vacation requests? N-not that I have forgotten where I put the one you gave me last week!"* She added rapidly, *" I just… It's good to have a back-up, right?"*

Catherine smirked. It wasn't too early for snide comments..

"Back-up is good. Back-up for back-up is better. back-up for back-up for back-up is getting a bit ridiculous…"

"Patricia says it's never wrong to be prepared, Wild-cat!"

Catherine was silent for a second.

"You're too pure for this world, scorp."

"Oh. Um… okay…?"

Catherine was more or less fully awake now, but still very much pre-tea. She wasn't ready to go full-sap either so she quickly added: "Okay, Scorpia, I have stuff to do. I will get your form and we will come by around 11.45, okay?"

"Oooooh… is this the day when Sunday brunch finally becomes a double date?"

“Beg pardon?”

“You said ‘we’...” Catherine blamed the lack of tea for not getting Scorpias hint immediately, and her response was loud and rapid.

“NO! Christ, I meant *me and Adora!”*

A distant “Woof!” could be heard from the kitchen.

“Oh. Too bad.” Damn, Scorpia really sounded disappointed. Catherine frowned.

“Well, I am so sorry for not fulfilling your and Patricia’s romantic delusions! See. You. Later.”

“Ok, wildcat! BUT if it should happen, please inform us prior so I can make the table for four. Patricia would never forgive me if I greeted a guest wrong. Especially your date, wildcat.”

“LATER SCORPIA!”

And then she hung up, threw her cell somewhere and left for the kitchen. Next to her bowls, Adora sat expectantly, tail still wagging and tongue out of her mouth. Catherine glared back at her dog.

"You don't deserve any food. Not after that."

Adora didn't react, she blinked and panted like she always did. Catherine's irritation grew, and needed an output. Adora was a target as good as anyone. Catherine squatted down on the floor, looked the Golden retriever in the eyes and said slowly and angrily:

"Do you understand what you have done? You did WRONG! Wrong! Bad dog! Mommy's HURT!"

Adora's response was to bark happily and lick Catherine's face again. Catherine looked at Adora with a flat mouth. “I could probably kill you and you’d forgive me, wouldn’t you?”

“Woof!”

"You're too dumb to live.” Then she sighed and added, “But I guess you're too dumb to understand that too, aren't you, Adora?"

"Woff!"

Catherine sighed again and went to the pantry where she kept the dog food, took out a can, opened it and emptied the content in the bowl. Seconds later her head was inseparable from the bowl.

Catherine shook her head and went to the stove to make tea. As the water heated up, she made two sandwiches of hard bread, salad, thin sliced chicken breast and boiled eggs. It stood out from her normal eating habits, but it had stuck with her from a short dieting fase a few years back. If nothing, it made her feel like she was a better person than she was. She spent a few minutes while she waited for the tea to get ready looking for her phone, until she found it in the laundry basket. She went back to her bedroom, put on a new T-shirt and fresh underwear (And socks. Always socks in an apartment you shared with Adora. No pants. Not before tea.) She then poured herself the first cup of tea and ate the first sandwich while checking her Facebook and Insta.

Catherines full name was Catherine DaCosta, Cat for absolutely no one, wildcat for the few who dared (although when it came to Scorpia it probably was obliviousness to danger) and ‘Miss DaCoosta’ for her immediate superior. She worked as secretary/receptionist/angry voice on the other half of the complaints number in the firm Horde Security. Not a dream job, but it paid the rent, she got paid for being nasty to customers and it was close to home. It was also there she met Scorpia, who worked as squad leader at the same firm. Catherine sipped her tea as she let her mind glance over her friend.

Well, at least we have that in common that we can make a living out of our physical attributes.

Scorpia was huge, intimidating and strong as an ox. She was also the only one for which it was mandatory to wear sunglasses because "no one will ever succumb to those eyes. Cover them up or toughen up, Ms Scoretti." as Mr Hordak had put it after her first day on the field. Scorpia was as well liked by her colleagues for her good mood as she was disliked by Catherine for the same damn good mood and by her superiors for her messy paperwork. Catherine could have taken the paperwork, had it not been her responsibility to clear out the mess every damn time.

Just as Wildcat wasn't her real name, Scorpias name was Sophia Lisa Scoretti. It was Catherine that started to call her Scorpia, based on her surname, to get back to her after not getting the signals and *stopping calling her wildcat.* Unfortunately Scorpia liked it, and soon it had caught on all over the firm. Save for ms. Weaver, but she used everyones surname in every situation.

Catherine had looked over her social networks without giving Scorpia another thought until her snapchat chimed and another note from Scorpia occured.

Don't forget: papers. and call us if it's a date. Catherine rolled her eyes and threw away her phone again.

Date. F.O.

She decided to not answer as punishment. Her being single was *not* a problem, and it was *definitely* not Scorpia's business anyway.

"Woof" Adora looked briefly up from her bowl.

"No, Adora. This time it's Scorpia that's annoying."

"woof."

"I dunno, she just can't take a hint. Or a straight out message. Or threats."

"Woof!"

“I am not lonely! I don’t need anyone!”

“WOOF!”

"Yes yes. I have you. You don't need to remind me…"

She lifted her mug to her lips and began to devour the second sandwich. However, the time of peace was soon to end. The moment Adora had finished eating she ran out into the hallway. She soon returned with a leash which she dropped on the table.

"Woof!"

Catherine looked up, mug in hand. "Adora, I am still eating!"

"Woof! Woof!" Adora made a gesture with her head towards the window. Catherine rolled her eyes.

"I don't care that it's a beautiful day! I am eating!"

"WOOF" The dog made a sudden dive towards the edge of the table, trying to steal the last part of the sandwich. Because without her sandwich mommy was done eating, and then she would have time to go out, wouldn't she? But Catherine was faster, got hold of the sandwich and gave the dog a light smack on her forehead.

"ADORA! BAD GIRL! BAD!"

Adora whimpered and looked away. Then Catherine glared at her dog as she finished the other sandwich. Adora tried to come closer a few times, but Catherine hissed at her every time, which made her back off. But as soon as Catherine was done with the sandwich, Adora slowly approached her and placed her head on her lap.

"Woof?"

The woman sighed, smiled a little and petted the Golden Retriever behind her ears.

"I can't stay mad at you, you idiot. We're two crazy bitches you and I, aren't we, Adora?"

"WOOF!"

"Word. Alright. Let’s go outside. -But- Not a long run. I am NOT in the mood, okay?"

"Woof!"

"Yeah, somehow I don't believe you."

Pants and sneakers (and a scarf for Adora) later, they went outside. Adora wanted to take the stairs, but a pull on the leash got her into the elevator. It was still too early for three stairs. It was late summer and the air was still reasonably warm. Catherine had decided to wear just a top today and skip the jacket. They walked a few blocks down towards a nearby park. Adora was a happy and well behaved dog when she wanted to, especially when it came to going to the park. Those visits had been cut short before and she knew mommy well enough to be on her best side, at least on the way there, and she made no fuzz as they walked down the street. Catherine glanced occasionally in the store windows. In one of them she got a good look at herself. 31 years old, 5 feet 2, perhaps slightly more keen on Take-away than the gym. But over all, pretty decent. Her brown neck-long hair was pushing it's permitted length though, and she realized she also had forgotten to brush it.

“Damn. I look like I had really bad sex last night.”

“Woof!” She glared at her dog.

“You don’t HAVE to agree, Adora!”

“Woof!”

“Look, there’s the park! So, let’s make a deal. You get to run free, I can play on my phone. Don’t disturb me, don’t scare any kids, don’t catch any squirrels. Ok?”

“WOOF!”

“Dog biscuits IF you behave.”

“Woof.”

As they entered the park, Catherine let Adora run free and sat down on a bench. She played a few games, throwing a glance at Adora from time to time. The dog was running up and down like her tail was on fire, but she stayed within the park's premises and made sure not to upset Catherine. She knew that mommy could be really mean and not give her dog biscuits even if the squirrels were *totally* asking for it.

About an hour later Adora had run off her worst and Catherine had watched two episodes of a reaction channel and played five games of sudoku. Overall, a morning well spent. Catherine called Adora back, put the leach on, and they we're on their merry way to her office.

“Woof.”

“Not in the streets, Adora…”

“WOOF.”

“No, I still haven’t forgotten that time you hunted down a Mini Cooper. And neither has Etheria PD. So leach. On.”

“wöff…”

Catherine hadn’t planned to stay out for as long as they had, but as Adora had pointed out, it was a nice day, and time had passed rather fast after all. So she led Adora down a different path than the one leading back to the apartment and a 27-minutes walk later they arrived at the office. Opening hours were Monday to Friday 8-17.35, and since Catherine had planned to spend the better part of the morning dozing off (Adora would probably leave her alone for at least an hour) she didn’t think of bringing her key card. But she did what she always did, walked around to the back

door and began to bang it out. She knew the schedule to heart and knew exactly who was there and how to get inside.

It only took a few minutes before it opened, and Catherine stood face to face with Kyle and Rogelio, the odd couple of the firm. Kyle was as short and thin as Rogelio was tall and buff. It was also an open secret that against company policy they were in a long term relationship. Kyle stared at her in fear, and his wrinkly shirt told her the reason. Probably stealing some time making out instead of sitting behind the screens. Kyle probably knew she knew, and his pupils widened even more. Rogelio looked as cool as he always did, and if he was scared of Catherine (since she technically was their superior) he never showed it.

"'sup guys? Anything fun happening?"

"Wildc… I mean Cath… I mean, miss DaCosta! What are you doing here on a sunday?"

"Apuesto a que es por algo que Scorpia olvidó de nuevo, ¿verdad?"

"Right as always, Rodge. Actually guys, I'm in a bit of a hurry. How about a deal. You can play with Adora while I fetch whatever Scorpia may or may not forgotten to bring, you don't tell Mr Hordak or Weaver and I won't tell them how fast you got to the backdoor…"

Kyle would've probably let out a sigh of relief, had not Adora jumped him at "Play with ad" Adora loved Kyle, well she loved everyone, but Catherine was pretty sure the reason she liked Kyle was because he was so easy to push over.

Rogelio turned around to help him up, but as Catherine passed, he said "¿Aquí un domingo, wildcat? Realmente necesitas conseguir una novia."

Catherine frowned. "I can still call Weaver, Rodge…"

"Ya lo habrías hecho si fueras en serio…"

“Yeah, screw you too. Try to stop Adora from killing your bitch instead.”

Mentally she bit herself. Did she *really* have to get so damn nasty just because? Rogelio had only rolled his eyes, but still. *One day it will pass a line…* a small part of her mind said, but another replied *not this one, and he can take it* while a third added *but not as much as Kyle can!* Catherine groaned and concentrated on getting the papers in question, not that it was hard, but she didn’t want to lose her good mood. Why was everyone so concerned with her getting a girlfriend? Catherine could chew the fat with anyone, but she had a tendency to blush every time her lovelife (and potential lovelife) came into the discussion. She found the necessary papers soon enough and loitered around her desk for just a few minutes too long just for the joy of seeing Kyle being manhandled by Adora.

“Adora! Playtime's up!”

Adora turned to look at her with the biggest puppy eyes a full-grown dog could muster, while Kyle looked like he saw daylight for the first time in a month. *Yeah, Adora can be intense…* Rogelio just smiled, apparently he had a bit of a knack for messing with his bf.

“Playtime’s up, Adora. We must give Kyle time to recover. He has a long day of… work ahead and we don’t want him spent already, do we?”

Adora hung her head, but came over to Catra and let the leash be put back on her. Kyle blushed, and Rogelio once again rolled his eyes.

“Si no te conociera mejor, gata montés, pensaría que estás celoso…”

Catherine smirked. “Jealous? Never. Thanks for the help boys. I will remember this at the next evaluation meeting. Adora, stop whimpering. You can play with Kyle another day. Maybe we could

come by your place!? Lonnie doesn't mind roughing it up!” It was a joke, she wasn’t going to indulge Adora that much, but Kyle took her seriously (again) and began to wave his hands.

“N-no! I mean, normally that wouldn’t be a problem, but with Lonnie as she is… well”

Ah yes. Lonnie was expecting. Lonnie was almost the third part of a throuple, as much as you can be when being a Tibetan Mastiff. She was as big as Adora and not one to be pushed over by her, one of the few dogs Catherine and Adora knew. She had also a tendency to come up in every conversation with Kyle, and it alway sounded like the dog owned him more than the other way around. Adora shone up when she heard Lonnie's name and gave Catherine another dose of puppy eyes. She shook her head in return.

“Not today, Adora. Once the puppies are out, we can talk about it.”

“¿Quizás quieras comprar uno? A Adora le vendría bien un poco de compañía.”

Catherine laughed. Get another dog? oh no. Adora was more than enough. “No thank you. Well, boys. I’m leaving. Hands on knees from now on.”

As she left, in the distance she saw an imperative figure loom their way towards the main entrance. They didn’t see Catherine, and she let out a breath she wasn’t fully aware she was holding when she disappeared from her view. Sharon Weaver was her nearest superior and a true b-word in the not-dog meaning, and while she didn’t really have any business to be at the firm on a sunday, it was well in line with her personality. She was glad she was out of the building in time, and hoped that Kyle would get his shirt in order before she got there. Papers in hand and in the good mood you get from a narrow, yet waterproof escape from death, she and Adora walked to Scorpias and Patricia's place for the regular Sunday brunch.

"...and then I saw Weaver in the distance, walking the green mile to the office. I bet she sensed that Rodge and Kyle were sharing saliva in the burner room and that she had to 'cease that nonsense'." Catra finished her tale with a smirk, Scorpia laughed heartily and Patricia smiled her "doesn't really approve but can't help laughing" smile. Today's meal had been chili-themed and both Catherine and Adora were stuffed. While the humans spent the post-meal time having a cup of tea, Adora was dozing off on the carpet, while Frosta; Scorpia and Patricia's Malteser climbed all over her, trying to assert her dominance. It would have been more believable if she managed to stay on top.

"I tell you, Weaver has a sixth sense for that! The second someone is having FUN she feels pain somewhere in her body and has to stop it!"

"Yeah! She's like a vogon!"

Scorpia laughed at her reference, but Patricia and Catherine looked at Scorpia with blank eyes. Scorpia stopped laughing and looked at them with a frown.

"Come on guys! The hitch-hikers guide to the galaxy! You must have read it! It's about the destruction of earth and… and towels!"

Catherine's face was unhinged, but Patricia nodded.

"Oh that one… I didn't particularly enjoy it… But I am very happy you find joy in it, love."

"Thanks mate. But hey, Wildcat, you must know this! It was made into a movie a few years back!"

"Nah. British stuff is too advanced for me." Catherine leaned back and gave Scorpia a nonchalant smile. A shadow of annoyance played on Scorpia's friendly face.

“Look, guys… If you just took the time you would love it! It has something for everyone! Comedy, drama…”

“Sex?”

“...No, save for a brief mention in the fourth one…”

“Diversity?”

“...Ford is from Betelgeuze…”

“I don’t think that counts.”

“Guys, if you’d just… You know what… Forget it.” Scorpia frowned for a second. “But one day I will succeed!”

“Keep dreaming, Scorp. It will happen the day that…”

“You find a girl you like.”

Had Catra had some tea left there would have been a spittake.

“THAT ONE came without warning. Come on Scorpia, I wasn’t THAT nasty! No reason to get personal.”

“I think she is allowed a bit of light teasing, Catherine,” Patricia added. “But we will respect your boundaries. If you don’t feel comfortable talking about your love life, that’s okay.” Patricia wore that motherly smile that would lock up everyone's hearts once she was done with her degree in psychology and was ready for her own practice. *If only she could wait until she* had *that practice...* Catherine frowned. Patricia was as tall as Scorpia, but where Scorpia was muscular and bulky, Patricia was slim and thin, almost *Eternia’s next top model* -thin. And where Scorpias hair was short, Patricia's hair reached the floor of any house she visited. *Okay, not really, but it draws attention to her butt all the time.* And she loved flowers. Yuk. She had cute freckles, Catherine had to admit that.

“It’s not uncomfortable! I just don’t want to!”

"I do wonder what kind of woman would catch your eye, wildcat…"

"I HAVE dated, Scorp."

"Yeah, but you keep dissing them later, you always find something wrong with them. It's almost like you dig to find the fault in someone."

"Well, maybe I want to be sure that I won't be screwed over? Not everyone is like you, scorp."

"Does that mean you like me, Wildcat?"

"Keep calling me wildcat and it's a definite no on that one, *sophia."*

Scorpia opened her mouth, but Patricia put her hand on hers and shook her head. Scorpia shook her shoulders and gave her girlfriend a kiss. Catherine rolled her eyes, made a vomiting gesture and said "Get a room."

"This is our room, wildcat. What kind of Scrooge are you today?" She paused. "That's from…"

Catherine stopped her. "I have seen The muppets 'A Christmas Carol'. I do get that reference. Also, I was kidding."

"Oh. Ha ha. I totally got that!" she paused. "Also, you're not really a scrooge. You have too long hair. It suits you, but it looks a bit messy. You should start thinking about a haircut maybe?"

Catherine looked away. Her hair *had* grown longer than she actually liked, but money was going to be tight with the plumber, her food, *adoras* food, rent and… "I… Can't really…"

"I can give you the money, wildcat! No problem!"

"NO!" Catherine had to hold herself back from standing up. Discussing money was an even worse subject than her lovelife. "I

mean… Thank you. but I’m saving up for a PS5.”

Scorpia was never one to ask a follow-up question, which Catheries was happy for. Instead she just smiled and said, “Okay, wildcat. But you know, Patricia can help! She always cuts my hair!” Catherine looked at Scorpias hair, half-long on the top and mashineshort on boths sides.

“Can she do any other haircut than yours? YOU rock that butch style but I can’t really make that work.” She paused, but noticing Scorpia opening her mouth for a reply, she quickly added, "I am hot and sexy as it is. And I want a PS5 more than a girlfriend right now.”

“Right now hmmm? What would…”

Catherine groaned. "Don’t take everything I say so literally! I am, WE ARE well off on our own! I have Adora, I have you guys, I have the people at work! I don't need one or two people in my bed to be happy."

“Mmmmm, but it does make life a bit more fun, wildcat! The more the merrier...”

"Woof woof!"

“You see! Adora agrees with me!”

“She just thinks she will get more food if I get together with someone! Isn’t that right, Adora?”

“Wooof…”

Adora whimpered, very rare for the dog.

“Can we talk about something else now? Like a movie we all have seen so we can trash it?”

Patricia smiled and steered the conversation towards the newest season of ‘Euphoria’ and the evening ended pleasantly for all.

***

One week later. Adora had dragged her out of bed much later than usual, a whole half-hour later. Catherine was getting worried that she was getting sick, but she devoured her food as fast as always, so there was probably just this time. The week had been grey and raining, Weaver had been even nastier and more frugal than usual and Catherine had been convinced that her microwave had been broken until she found that Adora had managed to pull the plug when she was chasing her tail.

But now it was a new sunday, the sun was shining and things seemed to be pointing upwards. Patricia had promised indian-themed food, which made Catherine a bit extra eager to visit her friends for brunch. But first…

"Okay, Adora. You know the drill. Don't run away. Don't chase anyone, *especially squirrels!* "

"Woof!"

"They were not asking for it! They're squirrels! Let me sit down and I will play catch with you later, okay?"

"Woof!"

Catherine nodded, and took off the leash. Adora began to run up and down the stripe of grass where they usually spend their sundays. She knew the area, and she began to see if she could trace those squirrels, because even if she couldn't chase them, even if they were *totally asking for it, she* had to show them who was boss! Then all of a sudden she stopped. And sniffed. There was a new smell in the area, a very interesting smell. Reeeally interesting. Something big. Something strong. Something *doggy*! Somewhere… behind *that big bush*!

She ran off immediately and ignored Catherine's yelling.

"ADORA! COME BACK! ADORA! ADora! A…"

Where was it? Where did it come from? There? No, there! No… There…

Finally she found the origin. She was almost at the opposite part of the park, there was another mommy sitting on a bench, looking at her beepy thing while her dog was playing. Just like she and mommy used to do! However, this dog was HUGE. Almost a head taller than Adora. Now THIS was interesting...

“Woof!” Adora barked happily.

*****

"WOOF! WOOF! WOOF!"

"BARK!"

"WOOF! WOOF! WOOF!"

Catherine was running, and all her years of jogging could never prepare her for a sprint like this. The distance and the obstacles (Adora had ran *through* the shrubberies, she had to go around) had been the hardest but it had been easy for her to find where Adora had run. The sound of her happy, and VERY loud barking could be heard all over the park. All the worst scenarios ran through catherines mind, the very worst included kids… She loved kids, Catherine knew that. Especially small kids… Kids who tripped so easily… And was so easy to land on…

"Please don't kill them please don't kill them please tell me you're just trying to hug them…"

And then she arrived at the scene. Two dogs in a huge pile, connected with teeth at places on a body where teeth were rather bad.

And then another woman screaming.

“HUNTARA! HUNTARA! DOWN! DOWN I SAID!”

"ADORA!" Catherine screamed. Her first instinct was to protect her dog. Her second was to kill her herself as soon as they got away from here. She wasn't ready to go near them just just, but from what she could see, there was no blood at least. She drew a sigh of relief. Then she turned and screamed to the other woman: "WHAT the FUCK are you DOING? Are you trying to kill my dog?"

As cynical as Catherine was, in her heart Adora would still be the clumsy little puppy that had followed her home from the pound years ago. Any sane idea that the other dog (A German Shepherd, btw.) probably was trained flew out the window, all Catherine saw was CLAWS and FANGS and REALLY STUPID HAIR!

The other woman stared back, two seconds of surprised silence and then she screamed back:

"What I'm doing? YOUR DOG ATTACKED US!"

"THIS LOOKS LIKE NO DAMN ATTACK TO ME!"

"HUNTARA IS JUST DEFENDING HERSELF!"

As on cue, Adora managed to tip Huntara over, nibbled on her ear a bit and then jumped back and ran away again. Huntara was quick on her paws in pursuit and the game was afoot again.

"Well… YEAH! DEFENDING!"

"THAT'S NOT DEFENDING, THAT'S PURSUIT!"

As Adora came running out from the bushes towards them with Huntara hot on her tail, Catherine stepped out. She gave a short order. "Adora. Down."

Adora was never sure when she had crossed a line, but she did know when she was *way past* that line. From the look on mommy's face she had crashed and broken through at least five. Catherine stepped in between the dogs, and since Huntara was trained she stopped and backed away from the intervening human. Adora just lay flat against the ground, whimpering.

Catherine fastened the leach as she spoke. "That's right, Adora. Lie down and STAY down."

"Woof…"

"Thank you."

The other woman was almost as loud as her dog.

"Huntara! Stay!" then she turned to Catherine, "What were you thinking, letting that beast loose? People like you shouldn't be allowed to have dogs!"

Catherine stared at the other woman, breathing through her nose. What kind of person was this? And who in their right mind had *purple* hair? That *sparkled?*

"Oh!? *I* shouldn't have a dog? What about YOU then? That dog is twice your size, *Sparkles* ! You trying to hold her back would be like stopping a train with a ball of yarn!"

"WHAT did you just call me?"

"You heard me, Sparkles Sparkly-face!"

The other woman looked like she was going to explode. "You...you...Your dog was attacking me!"

"Well, YOUR dog was KILLING my dog!"

"No she wasn't! She was defending me!"

"She was PINNING HER TO THE GROUND, AIMING FOR THE THROAT!"

Catherine was almost in the other womans face now, well, as much as you could when the other one was shorter than you. Catherine wasn't that tall, but she kinda liked the feeling of finally towering over someone. (She was deeply jealous of Scorpias ability to just stare down people) The other woman blinked and

she seemed to swallow, but she pointed a finger in Catherine's face and replied, "Well, it's not like YOUR dog was any better!?"

"She is a TON better than YOUR dog!"

The sparkling woman opened her mouth for another reply, still pointing at Catherine. But she closed her mouth, closed her eyes and shook her head.

"Huntara. Let's go home."

Catherine wasn't ready to let things go just yet.

"Huntara. What a stupid name."

The other woman was already a few feet away, she stopped and said over her shoulder: "Oh yeah? What do you call your dog, ass-face?"

"Ass-face is a stupid name!!"

"Ah, so you do call her ass-face then."

Catherine bit her lip. She had walked right into that one and she was so angry she couldn't come up with a reply. Instead she focused on her still whimpering dog. "Adora. Up. We're leaving."

The sparkling woman snorted. " *Ador* a. What kind of a name is that?" And then they turned and left..

"It's a good name!" Catherine shouted after them.

"Whatever, idiot!" the other woman replied.

They walked home in silence. As they had closed the door behind them, Catherine sat down. Adora tried to climb into her lap, but Catherine pushed her away.

"Down, Adora. DOWN. STAY."

"Wooooof…"

Silence.

"I am VERY disappointed in you, Adora!"

"Woof…"

"Yeah, woof all you want! You have been a bad, bad girl! A really bad girl! You DON'T run away from me. You DON'T start fights with other dogs."

She was silent for a while.

"And you don't make other dog's owners yell at me. Especially those with really stupid hair."

Adora made the biggest puppy eyes possible as she lay on the floor. Those big blue eyes could usually melt an iceberg but not today.

"I ought to leave you at home. You don't deserve Patricia's special dog stew. But I don't want to disappoint her so you're coming with me anyway. But don't think you're out of the dog house! NO BISQUITS. NO PARK FOR A MONTH. You. Have been a BAD DOG."

Geez. Mommy was mad. And that made Adora sad, she didn't like it when mommy was upset with her. Usually it blew over quickly but now…

"Woof."

"Shut up, Adora."

Catherine bit her lip. Maybe she was overreacting but Adora HAD misbehaved. She had completely disobeyed her and that HAD to lead to consequences! Yes.

…Alright, so they weren't really killing each other. Probably. Adora was playing, she loved playing rough. The other dog… 50/50 between roughhousing and assaulting. But Adora could take it. Probably.

And that WOMAN. God, she was a piece of schtick. Catherine knew the type.

Expensive clothes, expensive dog, expensive makeup, expensive haircut (overprized, but still expensive). and high heeled combat boots! Who wore high heeled COMBAT BOOTS? Oh, she knew the type alright! She had met tons of them. At school, at the office, in shops, at the beach,… And that look she had given her! Oh, Catherine knew *all* about that type.

"Yeah, must be hard to meet a real, alive person who *works* to get her money and…"

She cut herself off, she didn't want to think about that woman again. She had to clear her mind. She decided that going outside was the best method, and to really show Adora what a bad dog she had been she put on her jogging outfit and called for her dog.

"I'm going for a jog, Adora. You are NOT coming."

"Woof…"

"Yes Adora. Woof indeed."

Taking a run without Adora was odd, but … Dammit, she HAD misbehaved. Really. She needed the punishment. Her mind cleared, she calmed down. By the time she reached the halfway point of the local bakery, she realized that she missed Adora trying to pull her inside for a brownie. (She never got one and it was bad for her, but such trivialities would never stop Adora…) she sighed, and realized she had automatically slowed down to having a better stance when pulling Adora back.

Perhaps it was a bit too much with no park for a month. Just a timeout would probably do it. As she got back home, she took a shower, and sat down on the couch. Adora had not left the floor during that whole time. (The saliva poodle beneath her proved it.)

Now Catherine called for her.

"Adora. Here."

Quick as a weasel, Adora was next to Catherine.

"I can't stay mad at you for long, you idiot."

"Woof!"

"Just… Try to keep a little bit more distance next time, ok?"

"Woof!"

"Now, you still did wrong! So no biscuits!"

"Woof…"

"Today. Maybe tomorrow. If you behave at Scorpia's. Okay?"

"Woof!"

Brunch o'clock had come and passed. Now they were back in the apartment, around 3 p.m. Catherines mood had been lifted after the, as usual, delicious meal. Catherine was the born carnivore, but Patricia's vegan food was something else. It actually tasted like food. Scorpia and Patricia were good people. In small portions.

Adora was sleeping in a corner, snoring like an old gran. Patricia's homemade dog food was so damn nutritious, and rich in protein that Adora would be out for hours. Frosta had been locked up in the bedroom most of the time today. They needed 'some time apart' as Patricia put it.

Catherine took the opportunity to shower. She rarely did at home, since Adora loved water as well, but with her asleep she had the time for giving her brown locks a good do-over.

"It takes blood, sweat and conditioner to get this hair" she usually said when someone complimented her.

Okay, it had been two times. Still a good line.

After the shower (no blow dryer, just towels until Adora was awake.) Catherine put on a pair of shorts and a linen and fell down on the couch. Her plan was to nap until Adora's unrelenting wake up call around 7 p.m.

She closed her eyes but sleeping didn't really work out. Because there was this face plastered on her retina, every second she closed her eyes.

The stupid dog lady from the park.

Catherine saw her stupid face again, how that big mouth had been yapping at her like a damn excavator!

And she stared at her with those big stupid eyes… What the eff was wrong with her eyes?

And that HAIR.

Had it really been sparkling?

Catherine gave up after half an hour and spent her afternoon playing video games until Adora got hungry.

Another week passed. Another Sunday.

"Woof!"

"Adora, I am begging yooooooouuuaaaauch!"

As she watched Adora's happy tail disappear into the kitchen she said to herself:

"I will NAIL the mattress to the bed… But I bet then she would bite my leg and pull me out of the bed…"

Her phone beeped. Scorpia. A reminder about brunch and *could you please pick up my back-pack from work? Please? Pretty please?*

"How does one even forget a back-pack... I am surrounded by weirdos!"

"Woof!"

"Yes, I am including you in that category!"

"WOOF!"

It was a cloudy day, fall was coming up fast this year, and they left the house rather late, since Catherine didn't want to stay out longer than necessary. They got to her office (main entrance this time, no Weaver luckily) to get the backpack and then some running time for Adora as compensation.

"Okay Adora. Normal rules. And no misbehaving, okay?"

"Woof."

"No, I don't trust you. Now stay. Stay! I will unleash you, and you will STAY okay?"

Adora didn't answer, and as Catherine unleashed her, Adora ran away almost instantly. Catherine swore and started to run after her.

"ADORA! ADORA! GET BACK HERE THIS INSTANT!"

She already had a vision of that stupid dog lady screaming at her again. This time she had visions of a bleeding Adora hanging from the jaws of the beast that wicked woman called a dog. But as she went around the bushes, all she found was Adora standing still on the grass. There was no one in sight, save for a guy on a bike in the distance. Adora was completely still, until she heard Catherine and turned her head. Catherine stared in surprise at her dog. She looked… sad. She had no idea Adora COULD look sad. She came back to Catherine, whimpering.

"What is it, Adora? Did something hurt you?"

Adora whimpered and stroked her head against Catherine's thigh. She kneeled down next to her dog and stroked her over the head.

"Hey… hey… It's okay. Mommy's here. It's okay. What is it? “

But the dog didn't answer. She just lowered her head and poked her nose against Catherine's thigh again.

"The...leach? You want the leach?"

"Woof."

"Why do you want the leach? ...Do you want to leave? Already?"

"Woof."

"Eh… Okay. Let's go then."

For a second she had been worried that that woman and her monster of a dog had been there, that they were the cause of Adora’s dismay. But now she was glad they hadn’t been there at all. Not only was Adora safe, Catherine didn't have to see that stupid face again, with that stupid big mouth and that weird hair. And her eyes. And those damn Clothes! Who wears that kind of outfit on a Sunday? For a second she wondered where she could be, but she let that one fall quickly. Who cared anyway? She wasn't there to shout at her, and that was all there was to it.

With some slight tugging she managed to get Adora to follow her to Scorpia’s. But she ate very little of her food, and let Frosta have her way with her the whole time. Even Patricia looked worried. No one said it out loud though, and Catherine made sure the conversation never led into anything Adora-related. Because it wasn’t anything to worry about. Really. Nothing that a good night’s sleep would take care about.

As they came home, Adora went to her usual corner and lay down. She didn't get up anymore that day until dinner. Catherine tried to tell herself that she was glad the damn dog was still for a change, but as the evening passed, she got more and more

worried. And she wasn’t the only one, that night she got the shortest text from Scorpia ever.

Is Adora sick?

She replied that she didn't think so, but she would call the vet later. That night she slept on the sofa so Adora wouldn’t be alone. In case of.

But Monday morning saw Adora wolf down her breakfast as usual, and as the week went on, Adora returned to her usual self more and more for every day. And on Sunday, Catherine found herself dragged down to the floor again.

"I need to get a door…"

"WOOF!"

This time, the visit to the park was involuntary. Adora more or less dragged her there, and once there she dragged her around the whole park. Catherine had no intention to let her run free this time, even if she had to walk as well. Adora went all over the park, looking for something. A few times she stopped and sniffed the ground or a tree. But in the end there was nothing. The walk home was slow and Adoras head hung close to the ground the whole time.

That day was the first day in months that Catherine had to cancel brunch. She couldn't get Adora out the door after they had returned to the apartment and she didn’t want to leave her alone. Scorpia had made very little fuzz when she called her on the way home to cancel. She just made a "naaaw" sound and said she would call back later.

Seeing Adora this sad made Catherines heart stop for a few beats. She lay down on the floor next to her dog and started to stroke her over the back and tail. Adora looked back at her with eyes that seemingly wanted to cry.

“Adora… What has happened to you…” But for once, Adora didn’t answer. She just moved closer to Catherine, who put her arm around her dog. *This is ridiculous!* she thought to herself. *I can’t cry because my dog is sad!* but she did.

Sometime during the afternoon she must have fallen asleep, because she woke up to the sounds of pots and pans being handled.

Now she understood the lack of reaction from Scorpia. The woman in question was standing right inside *her* apartment. *Cleaning* . while she was humming something that probably was ‘freebird’. And at the stove was Patricia, looking all rosy and sweaty over something Catherine knew she would never be able to pronounce, but smelled delicious anyway.

"Ah! You're awake, wildcat!"

Even if she was sort of glad to see them (even if it mostly was ‘Geez, I’m happy you’re not burglars) she frowned. "Don't call me that! And how did you get in?"Even if she knew it well enough, she always found it surprising how BIG Scorpia actually was, especially when you were looking up at her. She was a head and a half taller than Catherine, built like a brickhouse and had arms the size of legs, and legs the size of steel bulks. She also had a temperament akin to Adora, a big strong muscular teddy bear. *Such a waste of muscles… She should have become an assassin.*

"The door wasn't locked."

Oh.

"Okay, but why are you here then?"

Scorpia shared a look with Patricia who smiled. "Well… Most of the cooking was already done, and you know Patricia. She hates to throw away food.” Patricia smiled at Catherine, but slowly shook her head and pointed at Scorpia. Catherine nodded, she hadn't bought that explanation either. “ And we know how much you and Adora appreciate it." she added quickly.

Patricias lifted an oven glove covered hand in a salute, and returned to her pots. Catherine was more rudely awakened than actually angry but she still said "Food better be EXTRA super today. And next time, CALL."

She made her way to the bathroom to remove any traces of possible tears, but luckily enough she only looked like she had been sleeping

Food was delicious again, as it always was, and Catherine had to admit that if she was to be burgled, she preferred to be burgled from people who gave her stuff and cleaned up after them.

Even Adora could be persuaded to come and join them for brunch. And she ate all of it, although slower than the wolfing she usually devoted herself to.

"So, did the vet find anything?" Patricia was a few years younger, and still at uni, studying to be a psychologist. Catherine wasn't very keen on answering any of her questions these days. She usually ended up talking about her mother, and ONE therapist was enough, thank you very much. But a question about Adora would probably be safe, she thought to herself. Also the answer would be pretty harmless.

"Well, we never went. She was back to normal, her normal that is, by Friday. So I figured it was nothing."

Scorpia shot Adora a worried glance."Sure doesn't look like nothing, wildcat! She never eats this slow."

"Okay, yeah, today is worse, but I mean… we haven't done anything. We went to the park, but…"

"Aha! The park!” Patricia pointed a finger pointedly. “That is significant!"

"Nah, why would that be significant? We've been there before without a hitch!"

"Yes, but it was after that visit she was like this the first time. Did something happen in the park? And while we're at it, does she get enough exercise? That does have an impact on a dog's mood."

Catherine gave Patricia a look over the rim of her glass. "Are you trying to be a dog whisperer too?"

Patricia got a rather cute wrinkle on her forehead when she was getting annoyed. "We *do* have a dog, Catherine. We have some knowledge about them. So, please answer my question."

Catherine put down her glass and spoke, "Well, I try to take her to the park once a week, we go jogging at least thr… two times a week, stop looking at me like that scorp! Octavia likes to bring her along when she patrols the school grounds, which is about four times a week, I am not really allowed to bring her to work, but I sometimes do to annoy Kyle… That's plenty if you ask me." Catherine started to feel annoyed, even if it came from a good place, Patricia was nosy! "Look, there was nothing! Okay, she did run away from me again, but save for that nothing happened out of the ordinary."

"Aha!"

"Aha what?"

"You used the word *again* ? So she has done that before? Can you tell me a little about her social life?"

Scorpia's eyes glittered. "Man. I just love it when you get all serious and ph'd-y, babe!"

Patricia gave Scorpia a peck on her cheek. "Thank's sweetie. But please don't interrupt the session."

Session? Really?I swear, if you bring out a notepad, I will kick you… "Her social life? Well, She has me, and you guys and Frosta… but that might not count… and Lonnie from time to time."

"Yes, but what about dog's her own size?"

“There aren’t many dogs her size.”

Patricia frowned, which was so rare Catherine raised an eyebrow. “You know what I mean. Dogs around her size then.”

“Yeah yeah. Well, nothing. Well, save for that… Oh no.”

Catherine closed her eyes and facepalmed. God, had she been STUPID.

“There was this… other dog in the park. A big one. A really big one.”

“AhAAA!” Scorpia. Catherine glanced at her. Patricia nodded.

“Do go on?”

“Yeah, when she ran off the first time she… She was fighting with this dog…” She fell silent. After a few minutes, Patricia continued.

“Sometimes, understanding dog behaviour is a bit hard. Now, are you sure they were fighting?”

Catherine gave it a deep thought. Had she been? Was she? “Um… I did at the time… I mean. Adora wouldn’t know the difference between a real fight and a play fight even if she was bleeding… She would see it as a game anyway but… Now that I think about it…”

“Perhaps you should tell us everything, from the beginning? It might clear things up for all of us.”

Catherine swallowed and let her mind go back to that Sunday two weeks ago...

***

Adora was so *very much a goofball and the happiest dog around but if there was one thing she felt sad about was her size. She was big, actually even bigger than the average Golden Retriever.*

People who saw her sometimes wondered if there was a trace of bear somewhere in her genes. She was a very social dog, she loved company and she loved to play with other dogs. However, she had almost no playmates. She did play with Scorpias and Patricia's Frosta, but she had to hold back most of the time. (The Maltese WAS fierce, but Adora almost broke her bone once while they were playing catch.) She wasn't allowed near the dog cafe after the incident with the Bulldogs. Apparently you can get them to run. And Lonnie was a grump.

But THIS dog… Almost a head taller than Adora. Strong muscular forelegs. A back that one small human could sit on. THIS one would probably not mind some fun!

Adora approached the dog in a gentle manner, meaning that she ran fast towards them as she barked happily, tail spinning like a copter.

*****

On the bench, the other woman looked up at the unknown dog that came running towards them. She wasn't afraid of dogs, but an unfamiliar dog running straight towards her? Sure, it looked *friendly but… And barking like crazy! She may have moved a bit further away and then…*

"Huntara! Guard!"

*****

Huntara was a prime specimen of a watchdog. A German shepherd, tall and muscular. She knew she looked scary and she knew how to behave even scarier, especially when her missy asked her too. And this dog, this… intruder was getting very *close to Missy's personal space. She stood at attention, her weight shifted forward, head high and tail slowly wagging to her left. Everything in her posture screamed "back off."*

Adora did not back off. She did stop a few yards away, tail still spinning and yappering friendly and happily. She ran a few yards

around herself, and barked expectantly.

Huntara was confused. She had done everything she had learned in training, and this damn dog was yapping *at her? Such insolence! Such unworthy behavior! And now she pulled her scarf off and threw it in the air and caught it! That scarf, a symbol of the sacred bond between dog and owner, and she… this blasphemist PLAYED with it!*

And she was getting awfully close.

"Woof!"

Now, Huntara never played. She wasn't that kind of dog, she was exercising, training, practicing. And yes, normally, by now she would have attacked or at least lunged at this… invader. But unknowing to them, both dogs shared an experience, although coming from two different arenas. Where Adoras biggest disappointment was the lack of playmates, Huntara's disappointment was the lack of enduring sparring partners.

Huntara took in this other dog. Not as big as her, but really, who was? Enthusiastic though, and there were *a lot of muscles on those bones. Way too much fur. Well-kept teeth. Nah, she was no watchdog, not by far.*

But she looked like she could take the heat. Finally she might have found just the one…

And with a loud bark, she jumped on Adora. Adora answered to Huntaras jump by headbutting her, then she backed off a bit and tried to jump up on Huntara's back. Huntara growled and shaked off Adora with ease. Then she managed to tip her over and pin her to the ground as she tried to find an opening to bite down her neck. Adora barked, loud and excited, after a while she managed to get loose and ran straight into a nearby bush, Huntara at her tail. Soon they were back in the middle of the field, struggling over who would be on top.

There was a lot of noise, lots of teeth and lots of sweat and adrenaline.

To put it short, Adora had the time of her life!

Huntara had to admit it was pretty fun. The other dog didn't take it as seriously as she would have preferred but she fought like a true watcher. The fact that her Missy stood on the side and kept giving her orders was ignored at the moment. Disciplinary actions were to follow, she knew that. But right now she really didn't care.

Now, dogs playing can sometimes look, and even be, pretty rough and violent, but good owners who know their dogs and prepare them, know what's a fight and what's not. They know when it's time to step in and when to just let things go. Now, with two pent up dominant females, even for the trained and experienced owner, playing looks very much like a showdown from a superhero movie, although with sharper claws.

And it was about that time that Catherine arrived at the scene.

*****

"...And then she said 'what kind of a fucking name is Adora' and then she left. Oh god I have been so stupid… They must have been playing, they must have! And there I was, screaming… And THAT WOMAN…" She paused to cool herself down with some water.

Patricia nodded and took the opportunity to speak. "Yes. To Adora, it was probably just fun and games. She is a big dog after all, and it is probable that she has been looking for a dog her size to really rock it off. And when revisiting the park, she remembered the last time and she probably expected to meet that dog again!

And when she wasn't there…" Patricia paused. "Well, you see how she looks now."

"She's pining for the fjords!"

Catherine and Patricia stared at Scorpia.

"What?"

"Oh, come on guys! The Norwegian blue! The dead parrot! You must have seen it, it's a classic!"

"Yes dear, it's all good." Patricia patted Scorpia's hand and looked at Catherine again. "I say it's pretty clear what you need to do. You have to find that dog again."

Catherine shrugged her shoulders. "Oh yeah, because that is so easy! I should just check the register to see if I find a huge German Shepherd named… whatever that stupid name was."

"Whatever? That is a stupid name for a dog!"

When Catherine and Patricia looked at her deadpan, Scorpia sighed. "Can you guys NEVER take a joke? Oh whatever… I'm off to the dishes. But hey!" She stopped herself halfway up from her chair. "How did the owner look? Maybe we know her?"

Catherine groaned. "In a town this big? Oh, SURE! But, it's not like I have anything better to do. So, she was shorter than me. Not much, perhaps she reached up to… here?" Catherine showed with her hand a few inches down on her forehead. "That was WITH heels though, but I bet she even sleeps in them. They looked like that, had I been able to afford, and I wouldnät have wanted it anyway, I would. Or… whatever! And her hair was stupid! SOme kind of purply pink! It wasn't even a hairdo, it was just fluffy. Not like mine fluffy, she looked like she had… a damn cake on her head. And she *sparkled* . Sparkled like a damn drink on new year's eve. Oh, and she was chubby. That weird kinda "I have hips but I can still buy expensive clothes-chubby. And then it was her eyes… They were. Big. I mean, like HUGE. Dark brown.

And she had this really teensy tiny nose. And she blushed like heck when she got angry.” Catherine paused. “ Made her look really really dumb. And… Why are you smiling like that?”

“Nothing wildcat. Just admiring your ability to nail someone's personality with so few words. Go on.” Scorpia’s eyes were sparkling. Catherine gave Scorpia a long look and breathed through her nose for some minutes, but eventually she continued. “As I said, she had expensive clothes. Can’t really say anything about the brand, but they cost more than the suit I wear at work, that’s for sure.”

Scorpia snorted. “Yeah, try to get Miss Weaver to buy anything in another place than the 3-dollar store!”

“Heh. Yeah, if she could, she would demand that we buy the fabric ourselves and sew them.” Catherine was happy for the opportunity to change the subject from that annoying woman and to her favorite subject: Trash-talking her boss.

“Or wore uniforms made out of burlap!”

“And we would have water pistols and cucumbers instead of guns and batons!”

“For real!”

The two women laughed, slightly louder than the exchange was worth. Patricia on her hand had been quiet for some time, but now she spoke. “I think I know who it is.”

“WHAT?” Catherine shot up from the sofa, but after sitting down for the meal all the blood rushed and she had to fall back again. “Ouch… But really. What? YOU know her? REALLY?”

“Well, I don’t know her name… but I have seen her at the yoga center. And she has brought a dog a few times. German Shepherd. The way you described her haircut was ...rude, but I must admit it was quite on the spot.”

Catherine sank down into her sofa, hand covering her eyes. “Perfect. Now all I have to do is to stalk the yoga center. Great.”

She felt a hand on her shoulder, Patricia stood there with her hands on her cell, a message sent and a reply incoming. “I don’t think you have to go that far actually."

Brightmoon Boulevard. The classiest and most shallow street in town, and the location of the yoga center where Patricia worked extra. While Patricia didn’t know the name, and was not keen on breaking the client's integrity to get the address from the register, she had a friend who worked at the Moonbutts Coffee next door. Said friend had served stupid hair woman lots of times, and would probably remember her. Which she did.

The answer had read *why you wanna know that? She’s called Glimmer, or whatever. Comes by every tuesday and thursday after the speed yoga class. She seems cool, but damn, that hair.* Catherine had smirked as she reached this point in the text. *She also comes by on saturdays, around 1.30 p.m. Sharp. She has a dog, huge damn thing. Would probably eat Sea Hawk if he tried to get friendly with her. Think the dogs named Huntara or something. And she comes with a bloke. skinny tall guy, always wears a crop top and tight yoga pants. Ungh. Like, do people WANT to expose their junk to the world? They always order skinned chai and granola bars, but I have seen her throw dirty looks at the cinnamon buns.*

And here she was now, Moonbutts at Brightmoon Boulevard, at 1.25 p.m. on a saturday. She hated it already, and it was still a few weeks before pumpkin spice season, which even further diluted her annoyance. However, Patricia had apparently told her friend that she was coming, because an order had already been placed and paid for. Cathrine groaned but took the tray. Thé complet, with two scones, marmalade, cheese, fig marmalade and a few chocolaty things. It probably cost more than it’s worth, but Catherine swallowed her pride. The gift came from a good place,

and why look a gift horse in the mouth. And it was tea. You never say no to tea.

She prepared a scone and began to slowly devour it. She wasn't sure how long she had to wait, but maybe this person, whoever it was, wasn't as regular as Patricias friend had said? Adora was at her feet, chewing on some dog treats Catherine had brought. A whole lot of them, actually, otherwise she would have been on the chair next to Catherine, pining for the chocolaty things. She tried one of those next, with slight trepidation. Hmm. They had a nice orange flavor to them. A bit too sweet, but not bad.

But soon she was done with all her edibles, and she had never been good at letting her tea last an hour. She could probably ask for a refill, but she had her limits. And she didn't want to risk missing them by being in the bathroom.

She closed her eyes. This was just stupid, she should just leave. Adora wasn't worth this. She looked at her dog, chewing away on a fake bone. Okay, so maybe her goofball *was* worth it. But even so, how would this make *her* look to the other woman? A goddamn lunatic, that was how it was! She looked at her phone, another message from Scorpia. She had been peppered with a steady stream of texts from her friend since Monday lunch. Tuesday she had to work overtime, and Thursday afternoon she had chickened out. Today however, Scorpia had been working, patrolling some factories in the old spire area. Therefore she had a car, therefore she could drive Catherine. There was no escape. Catherine drew a breath, and clutched her hands together in front of her mouth in a pray-ish gesture. She closed her eyes and did a short breathing exercise. In. Ooooooout. In. Ouuuuut…

"Come on. You can do this. You have been making excuses for your company's lousy service for years. When you see her, walk up to her, apologize, let the dogs play, have your old goofball back and go home." But she was reluctant. She was pretty sure the reunion wasn't going to be pleasant. Adora on the other hand, had been overexcited. She had probably felt Huntaras scent since they were let out of the car, and had been jumping with

excitement all the way to the door, so much that Catherine had to pull the leash. “Adora. ADORA! Still, okay? There will be other people here and… Just behave. Okay?”

“Woof.”

“You can’t lie to save your own life.”

She looked at her watch, 1.47. Tea was cold. She shrugged her shoulders, better get that refill. And then the door opened and SHE entered.

Catherine was not staring at her. She looked as stupidly rich as last time, same hair, a pair of sunglasses (that kinda looked like her own, but which probably cost a lunch), a blazer over a dark red blouse and jeans. The woman wore fucking jeans. With those hips. Cathrine realized that she had been staring with her mouth open. How did she miss THOSE last sunday? She didn’t catch what the woman had ordered, had she even ordered? Apparently she had done it in the app, since the barista looked at her, asked “moon?” The woman nodded, took the mugs and a package and prepared to leave. She had already left when Catherine found the energy to move, and with Adora in tow she was out the door. *This was ridiculous! She should just leave. She had gotten a way out, use it!* But no. She had come this far, and even if Catherine was a bad starter, she was an excellent finisher. She looked up and down the road. She soon saw the backside of the woman, (and with THAT ASS it wasn’t hard.) and she began to jog after her. Adora wasn’t fully aware of what was happening, but she was always up for a jog, and soon it felt like they were hunting down a purse snatcher. As they approached, Catherine realised that if she didn’t call upon her, it would look like they were actually in pursuit of her and she wasn’t going to turn this Saturday into a b-action flick. She slowed down and said “Excuse me, miss?” No reaction. “Excuse me?” No reaction. Now Catherine saw the airpods, which explained why she hadn’t noticed them running (nor Adora's yapping.). Catherine walked up to her and patted her shoulder.

“Excuse me, miss?”

The other woman stopped and turned around.

"What's the m.. WHAT THE F… It's YOU!"

The woman looked like she was going to smack Catherine in the face, but at that moment, Adora noticed something. Further down the road came her playmate, with another human in tow. She barked happily in greet, and started to run down the path. Catherine, who had been frozen the second the woman turned around, was not prepared for the jerk from the leash and fell, face forward to the ground, as Adora ran towards the other dog, happily barking.

smack

"WOOF!"

"BARK!"

"Oh my god! Are you okay? Um… Huntara, stay?" The man ran up to the fallen woman and helped her up."

"Does it hurt?"

Catherine held her hand against her nose, which hurt the most.

"'nly my dignity…"

He looked at her, nodded, then he turned to the other woman.

"Glimmer? What happened? And why is your Golden Retriever trying to hump Huntara?"

The man had dark skin and seemed to be the same age as this… Glimmer, if that was her name.

"It'f a girl…" Catherine replied as she kept massaged her potentially crushed nose. "Though I wouldn't be surprised if she tried anyway. She is the dumbest dog alive."

"WOOF!"

"Can it, you are. You said you'd behave."

"Woof!"

"You call THIS behaving? Now SIT."

The man looked at her, then the dogs, then at this Glimmer. then at a couch a bit further down the road. “Can you walk? Okay, try to sit down there and let me have a look at it.”

“Bow, we are NOT helping her. She said she is fine!”

"Glimmer, she fell right in front of us. It's the least we can do."

"Thank you." Catherine glared at this Glimmer or whatever the name was. She sat down and let this Bow look at her nose. She wasn’t that hurt, but it gave her satisfaction to see how angry it made Glimmer. She saw in the corner of her eye how Adora was still trying to get the other dog to play with her. "Adora. Sit. Still. Wait. Or we leave THIS. INSTANT."

"Woof."

"Adora? Oooh" the man named now shined up. "You are THAT lady."

"Bow…" there was a low threat in Glimmer's voice, but he didn’t seem to be bothered.

“Glimmer has been talking a lot about you! The harpy and her shark-hybrid dog that almost killed her and Huntara!”

“BOW!”

“Look, Glimmer! This has been on your mind for too long, let’s get this straightened out once and for all. Let’s go to the park. I will get you a cup of… what do you want?”

“Blood, I think.”

“Glimmer…Tea?”

Catherine nodded. Bow smiled. “Good. Glimmer, take Huntara and… Adora was it? Okay, you can go ahead and we’ll meet up there.”

Ten minutes of very awkward silence later, the three humans were sitting at a table with the dogs playing on the grass. Adora and Huntara were getting along pretty well. From time to time they stopped their playfighting to behave like two bodybuilders who met at the gym and started to compare biceps. It was obvious that they were on friendly terms.

That couldn't be said to be the case between the two women. Glimmer had been glaring at her the whole time, while Bow tried to be pleasant. Catherine had no idea what to say.

“ I’m Bow. Bow Cratchett, you may know my dads? No? okay, not important. She’s Glimmer Moon. Real name Georgette.” Glimmer hmpfd. “Glimmer, better to let her know, otherwise… you know. So… Catherine was it? Tell us a bit about yourself?”

“Catherine Dacosta. And I’m…”

“She’s a jerk…” Georgette muttered.

“Glimmer… Go on!”

“I work at a security firm downtown. Horde Security, I don’t know if you heard of them.”

“Oh yeah. The rip off. Can’t even stop a candy theft. You look too small for being a guard, that would explain it if you're the standard employee.”

“Glimmer…That sounds like an interesting job. Are you working in the field?”

“I man the front desk, but I’m mostly in administration. Scheduling, billing, contracts and such.”

“Suits you. Office slave.”

“Glimmer… I am also working in administration, you know…”

“Yeah, but you’re at least working at a nice firm that doesn’t suck the blood out of its customers.”

“That… is up for debate…”

Catherine would have found the bickering funny, had she not felt the growing animosity towards Glimmer. And soon it had passed the point where she couldn’t be silent anymore.

“I at least have a decent job! A real job! I don’t have to live on mommy’s wallet!” That was a shot in the dark, but considering Glimmer hadn’t said a word about what she was doing for a living combined with the clothes, she could make an educated guess. And the arrow hit it’s target at the heart. Glimmer shot up from her seat and hissed at catherine.

“You don’t know SHIT about me and my life! But I can tell a lot from your mess of a dog that is… “

Georgette pointed at Adora, who was busy sniffing Huntaras front leg while the latter looked smug. Catherine hissed back

“Yeah. A *real* mess of a dog. The signs are obvious, aren’t they? I’ll have you know that Adora is a pureblood.”

“Oh? What kind of blood? Ketchup?”

“GLIMMER!”

Catherine sighed. She took a few deep breaths and stood up herself. Calmly she said, “This was a mistake. I am sorry for taking up your time. Thanks for the tea and the band-aid.” That was aimed only at Bow. “ We will leave now. “ She turned around to call Adora back. Behind her she heard a small thud, another small thud, then a significantly loud smack, followed by an “ouch! Okay, okay…” And then Glimmer said very slowly. “Okay, wait…”

Catherine turned around. “What?”

“Alright. Even if I don’t trust you to sit the proper way on a toilet seat…”

“Glimmer…”

“...It seems like Huntara has taken a liking for your dog. It will probably be beneficial to them both to hang out occasionally. My Sundays are free and the park is probably big enough for them not to cause too much damage. Shall we arrange a date? We can let the dogs play and don’t interact more than necessary.”

That sounded pretty nice to Catherine’s ears. It was a good enough compromise. She could sit on a bench, reading on her phone, not having to interact with this Glimmer woman more than “hello” and “good bye”.

It wasn’t like she was single anyway.

Next Sunday:

thud!

“ADORA!”

“Woof! Woof!”

“It’s just a playdate. Yeesus…”

***

“Sparkles.”

“Jerkface.”

"Fucktrumpet."

"Assclown"

“I will be over here.”

“I’m sitting right here.”

“Good.”

“Good.”

They let the dogs play for about an hour, and then went separate ways.

three weeks later.

“Sparkles.”

“Catherine Dacosta.”

“Oh, proper names? Really? I didn’t think you could spell.”

“One should always be polite when speaking to the mentally challenged.”

“Oh screw you *Georgette* .”

“No thanks. I will be on that bench.”

Two and a half weeks later.

“Hi Georgette”

“Hello Catherine.”

“I will be on that bench.”

“I will sit here.”

“Okay.”

“Okay.”

“Is it okay if I sit here? I forgot my raincoat, and the other sofa is a bit wet. If you don’t mind.”

“Nah, it’s okay.”

“Thanks.”

Same day, later.

“So, wildcat… How did it go with the woman?”

“Glimmer is the biggest idiot in the world. But her dog is nice.”

“Naaaw… you’re getting a new friend.”

“Stop. looking. at. me. like. that.”

Yet another week later. Saturday, since Sunday was thanksgiving.

“Catherine Dacosta.”

“That is my name, Georgette Moon.”

“Oh for god's sake! Just say Glimmer! Mom is the only one that calls me Georgette.”

“Alright. Glimmer. I thought it was a nickname only your boyfriend used.”

“Boyfriend?”

“Yeah, Bow, you know?”

“Oh, Bow? He isn’t my boyfriend. We’re friends. We tried once but it wasn’t meant to be us. We're just good friends.”

“Oh.”

“Yeah.”

"I… will sit over here."

"Yeah, ok. Actually.. you can sit here?"

“mmmkay…”

Some sufficient time later.

“Hi.”

“Hi.”

“interesting winterjacket.”

“Interesting? Well, interesting Cat earmuffs then, Catherine."

"It's a Gift from a friend, and they're warm. You have a problem with them?"

"No, no… not at all. I… They look nice, that’s all."

"Okay."

"Yeah…"

A few days before Christmas, at a cafe near Catherine's flat and the park.

"Catherine."

"Glimmer. Bow?"

"Hi Catherine!

"Nice to see you, what brings you here?"

"I felt this was a good day for you guys to have a real chat. A REAL chat." The last was added with a clear address to Glimmer.

"What?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Yeah, I said it was a stupid idea. But he was persistent."

"Come on, I bet you guys could be really good friends if you gave it a shot. Why don't you guys go to the park and sit down, I will get some tea. Or even better, isn't your place nearby, Catherine?."

Catherine silently wondered how Bow knew that, but it was possible that he also knew Scorpia or perhaps Patricia. These kinds of overfriendly people seemed to be drawn towards each other.

"...alright. And you don't have to get tea, my kitchen is stocked."

Bow smiled from ear to ear. Glimmer groaned. "Great! But let me at least get some treats! Save a cup for me, please?"

"okay. Lemon, sugar or honey?"

"Honey. Thanks."

***

9 minutes of polite but dry conversation later they arrived at Catherines flat, dog in tow. Huntara and Adora immediately lay down to rest on Catherine's bed.

Well, it's not like the dogs will be the big problem here... Did Glimmer just snort?

"What was that?"

“Oh, nothing, nothing.”

“It's not nothing, I know those faces.”

“Okay, okay… The bamboo drapery? …interesting.’

Interesting as in ugly, you mean? B-word…

Loud she said:

"Honey for the tea?"

"Oh, yes, thank you. Is it fresh from a farm?"

"Yeah, I have a friend who lives for organic and ecological stuff. She hooked me up on it. It's good stuff."

Glimmer took a spoon and ate it straight from the can. "Mmm! Good!" She took another spoon, and only the third made it to her tea. She stirred around in her mug for a while as she looked over Catherine's apartment.

“This must be expensive!”

“Nah, they charge pretty decent. 20 bucks for a big jar. Lasts about four months.”

“oh. Cool.”

Catherine should just swallow it, but she couldn’t stop herself.

“What, you didn’t think I could afford honey?”

“What? No! I was just…”

Glimmer had paused. The paus wasn’t much, but the ‘cease fire’ between them had been brittle, and she hadn’t swallowed her annoyance just yet. In that pause, Catherine read in everything anyone had said to her over the years and it was very easy to hear it in Glimmer's voice. "weren’t you going to say something about what a dump this is?"

“What? No! I was…”

“Oh yes you were! I can see it in your eyes! This is below your dignity, isn’t it, to even be in this neighbourhood!”

“I admit that Arachnia isn’t the first place I would visit, but…”

“And if you think my bamboo drapery is so ugly, you can fuck off! I know your type!”

“Oh. What kind of type am I?” Glimmer's eyes grew thin. Catherine saw the warning, but she had built up for this, even as things got more polite, she had been slowly fuming. And now it all blew out.

"I have seen thousands like you. Mom and Dad runs a business, hardly any time for you, spoils you but at the same time wants you to be a good little girl so you rebelled by getting large tattoos and started sleeping with bad boys and bad girls, trying to be 'street' but you never went outside without your credit card, and your doc martens were the real deal. And you never worked, until now when your Dad has given you a spot as vice president at the firm."

Glimmer's reaction wasn't what Catherine had expected. She gave Catherine a look that was more tired than angry. Catherine stopped herself, and Glimmer took over.

"So I am a snob, a bigot, a proper spoiled rich bitch who doesn't know what working means… I think that is all. Well, good on you. Well spotted, Catherine Dacosta. What a saint you must be. A real archangel. A real trusting person who doesn't hit first just to make sure no one hits her. Who doesn't assume that everyone is against her and definitely NOT insults her best friends just in case they decide to ever turn on her." Glimmer finished, and put down her mug. Glimmer shot the dogs a glance still laying side by side on the bed, Catherine was staring at Glimmer.

"...Whu?"

"Please. You're not some kind of mystery woman. You always have an insult ready, you treat Adora like crap and you're always defensive. It's not complicated."

Catherine's eyes grew wide but she had no idea what to say. She licked her lips a few times, her mouth had gone dry all of a sudden. Glimmer had been glaring at her, now she seemed to deflate. Then she slowly said, "This was a mistake. All of it. Thanks for the tea. And merry Christmas. No, scratch that. Good *humbug.* "

She rose from the table and went towards the hallway. Catherine bit her lip. Then she stood up.

"Wait." It wasn't loud, but Glimmer turned around.

"For what? Another dose of your insults and prejudices?"

Catras' arms clutched her belly. She looked at her teacup. Her tv. The dirty window. Anywhere but Glimmers face.

"...I'm sorry. I'm…really, Really sorry… I … I… please don't go."

She looked up from the table. Glimmer was already out in the throng. She had her high heeled leather boots in her hands, ready to put them on. But she didn't move.

She stood up from the table and walked over to Glimmer. "I am sorry. I *was* pissed that you were such a bitch but well… The first thing *I* did was to scream at you so… I suppose… oh fuck me, You had your reasons, okay? I am sorry, I didn't mean to lash out at you, I let my stupid temper get the best of me again and I don't want you to be angry with me. I know I have a bad temper and I hate the fact that I talk before I think and…"

Glimmer was silent, but she didn't make any further attempt to leave. Catra just let her mouth go. *Just say whatever. Can't make it worse.*

"I… People tend to second guess me. They look at me and think they know who I am. At least it always feels like that and…"

Catherine sighed. "I grew up in an orphanage. I have no idea who my parents are. I just know I am a Molotov-cocktail of genes. I look like every damn minority there is. No money, no parents… And I don't want anyone's pity."

Catherine closed her eyes. "I just want someone to look at me and see beyond what I look like and just see… who I am." She snickered. "Heh. Like Adora does." There was a long silence as they both looked at their dogs.

Glimmer broke the silence. "You really love her."

Catherine smiled, a genuine smile. "She doesn't care who I am or what I look like. Well, maybe I'm just the woman who feeds her but… She's always happy to see me. Always. Especially when I'm not in the mood for it."

There were a few more moments of silence as both women were staring at their dogs. In the end it was Glimmer who spoke first.

"My dad was Korean."

"Was?"

"Yeah. Was. Let's leave it at that."

"Okay."

"Mom always made sure I was to know that I was just like any other girl. But I knew from a fairly early age that I wasn't."

Glimmer looked up, straight into Catherine's eyes. "You said it. Rich. Because I *inherited* a damn fortune from my *dead father* . Spoiled. Because mom's way of dealing with the loss was to bury herself in work and throw toys at me to silence her bad conscience. And eyes that always make people look at me twice.

You ticked off every box. I just wish… once. That someone didn't start there. That they actually got to know me. First."

"And insult you when they do?"

Catherine bit her lip again. *Stupid stupid stupid mouth!*

Then Glimmer's mouth started to move. It started to shake and rustle and finally… She started to laugh out loud. It was not a dry angry laugh, it was the loudest belly shaking laugh Catherine heard. After a moment, she felt the corners of her own mouth move upwards and soon she was laughing too.

Glimmer had to sit down, she was almost crying with laughter.

Finally, she calmed down enough to speak. "You-you… You...you…"

"Yeah. Me me. Me. Mia. Meaow."

That made Glimmer laugh again, and for at least a few minutes, there was nothing but laughter in the apartment.

Finally: "You-you incorrigible jerk!"

"Yeah. I know."

"You're not supposed to make me laugh, you sod! I am supposed to be upset with you."

"Yeah. You ought to be."

Glimmer tried to get her voice steady. She swallowed a few times, took a napkin from her pocket to wipe off her cheeks.

"Okay. We're both kinda messed up. You want to be seen as who you are. I want to be seen as who I am. Our dogs pushed us together, but they're messed up as well so that went south immediately. Let's start again, from the beginning."

She stood up, and held out her hand to Catherine.

"Hi. I am Juliana Anne Diana Georgette Glimmer. I'm 29 years old, and filthy rich, yet still working as a practicing lawyer, specializing in inheritance and medical issues. I hate to work-out, but I do Pilates on Wednesdays and speed yoga on Tuesdays and Thursdays to keep my aunt from nagging me. I've known Bow all my life, he's my best friend and yes, we dated for five weeks until we realized we loved each other more as friends than anything else. Huntara was a gift from mom since she is convinced I will get killed by a thug any day. She plays tough, but give her chicken and she follows you to hell and back. My favorite flower is the sulphich rose and I am a huge Dr. Who-fan. And my favorite food is Chicken Nuggets."

Catherine took her hand and shook it.

"Nice to meet you, Georgette. I am Catherine Mia Dacosta. 31 years old, probably born on a Tuesday in June. I work as secretary and receptionist at the shadiest security company that exists. I practice boxing because punching things feels good, and I sometimes jog with Adora but how I keep in shape is a mystery. I have dated six of the ladies at work, none of them lasted longer than seven weeks and four of them quit afterwards. I followed my friends to the dog pound to help them pick a dog, they didn't find one but this shabby looking pup decided to follow me and that's how I got Adora. She is too friendly for her own good and loves everyone including me, meaning she's axe-crazy. My favorite flower is dog rose, YES for real and I could eat pizza for lunch, dinner and breakfast."

Short pause.

"And just for your information, I'm gay."

"Oh."

"Yeah."

"Eh… Yeah… I am Bi myself, I don't know… Some say I should say Pan, people say it's kinda the same, but since I have only been

with cis-people yet, I don’t think I could call myself pan within good concience and… Why am I even telling you this?”

“Because you think I am hot and that you want to bang me?”

“In your fucking dreams, Catherine. Do you have more tea?"

"Sure."

20 minutes later Bow returned.

"Hi guys! I’m sorry, everyone, their mothers AND grandparents wanted to buy pastries today. How did it go?”

Both women looked back at him from the sofa where they had been engaged in a deep conversation about whether the new Sex and the city installment was good or an insult. They looked up and made sick faces.

"Terrible, Bow. She's a psycho."

"Me? It's Glimmer who's the maniac."

"I knew the two of you would get along splendidly!"

***

Christmas dinner at Scorpias.

"This Glimmer…I’ve seen her a few times in the hood. She's kinda cute, don't you think?"

"No, I DON'T think so, Scorpia! She is an annoying c-word, that's what she is."

"Mhm. Well, if you say so. But her hair looks nice. Purple and shiny. Looks a bit stiff though. "

"...It's actually pink. but many people make that mistake. And it's sparkling. And it's actually pretty soft."

"Oh? And you know that HOW?"

"...Shut up."

"Only if you buy me lunch after the holidays."

Catherine did buy her lunch.

Two weeks later.

“Hi Catherine! Happy new year! Oh, You have a new shade of lipstick."

"Happy new year Glimmer. Thanks! Got it from a friend. It suits my colours, she said."

“You look ...decent.”

“Heh. Thanks.”

“I will sit on that bench.”

“Do you mind if I sit on it as well?”

“No.”

“Um...Can I ask a question?”

“I dunno, can you?”

“Bow... he’s Bi?”

“Pan. And transmasc, he got surgery last year.”

“And you’re telling me this because…?”

“He gets so sad every time someone sees the scars and looks surprised.”

“Okay, I will not make Bow-man cry. Got it. Wasn’t going to anyway. Are you trying to set us up?"

“Oh, no. Bow’s taken.”

“So why did you ask? Because you were wondering if I'm single?"

"NO."

Actually a Wednesday some time around 26th of January

"Catherine! Hi! And Adora, hi girl!

"Woof!"

"Hi Glimmer! I didn't take you as a wal-mart girl."

"Who is? But it's close. Also, They have a cute one at the register."

"Aha? How does she look?"

"Well… Brown hair, freckles, cute… heh, kinda like you, but with longer hair."

"...Did you just call me cute?"

"No! I was talking about a completely different person."

"Woof!"

"Shut up, Adora!"

"Good girl, Adora… good girl."

Somewhere between last time and the next time.

“Hi Glimmer!”

“Hello Cat! Ooh, new haircut? That's really short. It suits you.”

“Yeah. It's nice to cut down the forest at times."

"Oh, I hoped you did it for me?"

"Dream on. Can’t get it to fit under a hat like it was.”

“If you say so. It looks good anyway.”

“Oh, does it really?”

“Shut up, Cat. That bench? Mine.”

“Mkay.”

"Well?"

"Well, what?"

"Aren't you going to sit down?"

"You said it was your bench."

"And you're letting that stop you?"

"..."

"Besides, I can give a woman a compliment without wanting to shag her.”

“Shag. Do people really say that nowadays?”

“I don’t care, I like the word. ‘Let’s shag.’ it sounds… down to earth.”

“Says the woman who makes four times more than me a day.”

“Yes yes, rich bitch can’t understand the finer values in life. Please. I have seen you watch clips from Million Dollar Listing. As if you wouldn’t get a nice apartment if you had the money? ...Well, nicer. Your apartment was pretty neat."

“What? Sparkles being nice to me? What, do you want me to invite you over for tea again?”

“Maybe I do. Maybe I have wanted you to do that for some time."

“...”

“...”

“I only have Earl Grey this time."

“Do you still have that honey?”

“Of course.”

“Then lead the way.”

***

13th of February.

The apartment was big, albeit with a slight stupid floor plan. An L-shaped hallway led from the door to the living room, passing 4 rooms that should have been 3, and a dedicated kitchen. As you entered the apartment, the door on the left led to a very spacey bathroom, complete with a jacuzzi. It looked like it only fitted one but two not-that-tall-women could easily find space in it, apparently. On the right you had a small room that was useless for everything including being a wardrobe which was the current function. It was too small for an office, *way* too small for a bedroom, while also too big and not enough hangers to work as a wardrobe. The main reason for that was because the wallpapers were a nuance of green no one liked, so wardrobe it was. Passing

those, on the right was also a way too small dining room. It was an open space, where what was supposed to emulate a bar counter stood in the center, complete with bar stools around and a glass rack hanging from the roof. It didn't accomodate 8 people, which was the number of chairs, but at least it was pleasantly decorated, with modern art and a few selected greens on the wall. On the far end wall, a heavy hook was mounted on the wall, thick enough to hold back an angry ox. It was installed for a German Shepherd but was never used for it. Below it was a water bowl and one food bowl. There was another one a few meters away. Someone didn't want to be disturbed when eating, apparently.

The kitchen, which was separated from the dining area only with a low threshold on the floor, was almost ridiculously oversized. It seemed to be made for at least two chefs and three waiters, and the fact that it was designed to look like a 50's diner, with almost everything in a red nuance, made a guest wonder when they were getting served. But one didn't need to worry, the lady living there knew full well how to make a mess out of the entire kitchen when cooking. Catherine had to admit it was something of a feat. Also awfully cute, not that she would admit that. From the kitchen you also had access to the living room/lounge/tv-room/game room/office space. The room was indeed all of these things at once, although the first four were easily combined out of the two sofas, the gaming station, the air fresheners that by a miracle still was whole and functional and a TV. The office was hidden behind a thin paper wall on the right side, containing a small writing desk, a laptop and a printer, and a window with a nice view of the house garden. The room held a light yellow tone and the same art and greens decorated this room as well. Retracting through the hall one would find another door on the opposite of the diminutive dining room. It was a pretty ordinary door, slightly ajar, and it led to the master (and only) bedroom. Hanging from the roof was an imposing chandelier, a gift from someone who clearly bought it out of a bad conscience for not attending the housewarming party, and should have been kept in the bathroom as revenge, had it not been too big. When lit it spread a cold light on the room, not a corner was safe, everything was dragged into the

light and exposed. Therefore it was lit only on weekdays at 6.37 when one HAD to get out of bed, or you'll miss the bus for gods ache! Usually the lights came from candles, some of them actually smelling good. On the left was an antique chest of drawers in teak. It was extremely heavy, and never moved, even if there was to be a fire. Next to it was two wardrobes, one built into the wall, the other bought from Ikea about three weeks ago, because apparently you could use a few changes of outfits when you spent your weekends there. On the right was a mirror wall, one of the mirrors hiding a secret wardrobe (It did indeed withhold exactly what you think, and yes it was slightly open with some roughly removed items of clothing being thrown inside last night. The bed took up almost the whole room. It was queen-sized, and the two people sound asleep on it, wrapped up in each other's arms looked very small on it. Not that they cared, it was COMFORTABLE.

The tranquil scene was unfortunately doomed to be torn down soon, as four sets of paws could be heard walking over the tiled floor of the hallway and onto the fake hardwood of the bed room. Two dogs were now standing in the room, looking at their sleeping mommies. They shared a look, moved to the right side of the bed so they were facing the humans and let out a simultaneous bark.

"Woof!"

"Bark!"

Blue and yellow eyes looked into blue, gold and dark eyes.

"Adora…Get out. It's Sunday. Go and… chase a cat or something."

"Huntara. Leave."

"Woof!"

"Bark!"

The two dogs moved over to the footside of the bed. The shorter of the half-asleep women closed her eyes, smiled and tried to go back to sleep. The taller, however, knew better. She saw the look in the dog's eyes…

"Adora… you're being a bad influence here…"

"What do you… " And then the rather heavy mattress began to move… " Huntara! No! Stop! Back! Don'taaaaaa…"

Thud

"Huntara. You are a bad dog."

"Woof!"

"Bark!"

"Seriously, Adora is a real bad influence on Huntara. This hurts!"

"Speak for yourself, Sparkles. I landed softer than I've had in five years. Slept better too. How much did this bed cost?"

"Not enough to fill your big mouth with quarters, Cat."

"I can think of other things to fill my big mouth with… It's valentine's day tomorrow… Want a little sneak peak on your gift?"

"Hah! Knowing you, you already ate all the chocolate! "

"Maybe… kiss me and see if I taste chocolaty…"

"Don't think that I will forgive you that easily for eating my gift, Cat."

"...I didn't eat all of it, Sparkles."

"You'd better. ...I didn't say I didn't want a kiss."

"..."

"..."

"So… How did it taste?"

"Chocolate morning breath."

"Jerk."

"You know it. What time was brunch again?”

“11.25. They have a train to catch.“

“Mmkay. Still enough time to taste that morning breath some more…”

“Bark!”

"Come on, Huntara! Breakfast can wait!

"BARK!"

“Oh, shut up! You’re not my mum!”

“Woof.”

“Whose side are YOU on, Adora?”

“Mine, I hope.”

“Well, *Fuck you* , Cat. Oh, have you called Scorpia yet?”

“No… I don’t want to…”

“Coward. Do it or I will torture you with my cold feet.”

“Jerk.”

“You know it and you love me for it. Now call her. They deserve a heads up, and you have told me so much about Patricia's cooking that I don’t want to miss it for the world..”

“Can’t we just have pizza instead? I don’t want to tell her…”

“Cold feet approaching in 5…4…3…”

“Alright alright! Just let me get my phone… There. Hum hum hum hum… Um… Hey Scorpia… I mean Sophia. ...Yeah no I haven’t forgotten about brunch. Yes, actually… that’s why I am calling… Yeah, about the Brunch today… Um…Do you think you can set the table for four?"

A long silence followed, more than four minutes. Finally Catherine sighed and then she hung up.

“What did she say?”

“I don’t know, she was still screaming when I hung up...”

Fin.

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